



Good friends: Bjorn Borg and Vijay Amritraj exchange pleasantries on the sidelines of the Bengaluru Open ATP Challenger event in 2023.

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Amritraj Tennis (BAT) academy, being the president of the ATP Player Council (1989-93), a tournament director, commentator, and now the president of the Tamil Nadu Tennis Association (TNTA)... How did you manage all of these, and where does the energy come from?

When I finished my last Wimbledon (1990), I started doing television right away when tennis broadcasts started in India. It was a new challenge to be able to feed an audience that hadn't seen it before and to be able to share with them my thoughts and what the feelings were of a tennis player at Wimbledon. But at the same time, keep it entertaining so that [even] people who didn't like tennis would want to watch. I used the Dan Maskell phrase 'less is more' and didn't go on talking because it was a

visual and not like radio. That went on for 25 years.

I also wanted to replicate what my parents did for me [by helping] when I was young. And so when the United Nations (UN) asked me to serve as a Messenger of Peace, I served just under seven years for Secretary General Kofi Annan.

That opened my eyes further to what the world was and what the UN agencies did. I went to places I never thought I would visit because they weren't in Paris, London, or New York all the time. When my term at the UN ended, I started my foundation [VAF] to be able to help the needy in India.

In the meantime, I served as president [ATP Player Council] when we were building the ATP Tour as we know it today. Myself, Larry Scott, Tim Mayotte, Mark Miles, and all of us. These gave me a feeling of serving the sport that had given me so much, starting with my health.

About the BAT academy in Chennai....

Let me tell you how that got started. A very dear friend of mine was the

late Rajan Pillai, who was chairman of Britannia. I was on the board of Britannia because of him. Whenever I had a good year [results-wise], we didn't talk about the future of tennis in India.

When I had a bad year, Rajan would be like, 'Hey, what are we going to do after you?' He was a great lover of the game. One fine day, he said, 'Why don't Britannia and you get together and let's start something that is only an excellence programme? You design it and pick the guys; Britannia will fund it fully'. I said I could only do it if my mother agreed to be in charge. Mom said she would, and that's how we started in 1985.

And in that first set of eight kids was Leander Paes. It's amazing that as we sit today, Leander is in the player category at the Hall of Fame. It is like doubling the joy for me because he came out of a programme I helped start. For five years, he was with us [at BAT]. He won junior Wimbledon when he was with us. So, I feel even more bullish about what we've achieved this year at the Hall of Fame.